U.S. DEPARTMENT OF ENERGY'S
CYBERFORCE® PROGRAM

CyberForce® 101

C-Suite Panel Brief

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C-Suite Panel Brief 101 Guide

CyberForce Competition® Overview

The CyberForce Competition® is an in-person competition that provides collegiate students with a cyber-physical hands-on, realistic energy-based scenario to secure and defend that incorporates life-like constraints and tasks, actual end users, and continual emerging threats. Students are challenged by the opportunity to apply classroom knowledge in a real-life practical environment.

The goal is to build the pipeline of qualified cybersecurity candidates for crucial positions such as those in our energy sector, national laboratories, and industry. The CyberForce Competition provides an inclusive space for all participants, including collegiate students, mentors, industry, and academia.

C-Suite Brief Overview

The C-Suite Panel brief is one part of the *Orange Team score* in the CyberForce Competition. The primary goal of this area is to expand the soft skills of the competitors to include public/professional speaking engagements specifically tailored around technical topics and strategies to technical and non-technical executive audiences.

What is a C-Suite?

A C-Suite can refer to a group of high-level executives within an organization, typically in the Chief Officer roles. This typically includes the Chief Executive Officer (CEO), Chief Financial Officer (CFO), Chief Information Officer (CIO), Chief Operating Officer (COO), Chief Technology Officer (CTO), Chief Marketing

Officer (CMO), and other similar leadership roles. *It is important to keep in mind that the C-Suite is comprised of leaders who primarily focus on* ***business outcomes*** *rather than technical details.* C-Suite members may not have deep technical experience but do possess a strong understanding of business principles and strategic goals and outcomes. Keep your audience in mind while preparing any brief.

Benefits of the C-Suite Panel

Understanding the technical aspects of the infrastructure or attack is one thing but being able to relay that information to a non-technical audience and the impacts, risk, and potential consequences to executives who typically want to understand the dollar value is imperative. Most executives don't have much time to listen to a 30-minute brief and need that "elevator" pitch. The C-Suite panel focuses on how your proposed strategic ideas address identified business risks, improve the company's overall future position and protect its information. Your goal is to communicate the business risks of any provided problem and your proposed solutions in simple terms that address not only information security, but also the realistic monetary costs and justifications. Remember, the C-Suite needs to believe in the solution to buy in. (Think of this like Shark Tank)

C-Suite Communication

Communication is the key to success when addressing any level of management, regardless of the topic being discussed.

> **Understand the Organization/Audience.** Take time to understand what the mission or core values of the targeted audience are. Any information regarding current performance, staff initiatives, and challenges will provide you the ability to communicate regarding relevant topics

and contribute to meaningful ideas that align with company goals. If you hear that funding is tight, suggesting a very expensive product may be a major turn off. But suggesting a step ladder approach to that product may be a better approach.

- Simplicity is Key. It's easy to overthink and get caught up in the weeds of explanations. It's imperative to communicate your thoughts in clear, concise, and direct points that address each subject required. Sometimes less is more. Before responding take some time to process the full question and provide a direct and accurate response. Ensure your points are upfront much like a summary would be found in paper. What is the objective of the presentation.
- Structure. In order to ensure that your communication is easy to follow make sure you structure your ideas. Set the message based on the goal you want to achieve and drive that goal. Organize your ideas in concise, simple to follow points to guide your audience and help you stay on the key points.
- Nonverbal Communication. What we don't say can be just as revealing as the words we do say. Be mindful of your tone of voice, your posture, what you are wearing for they all say a lot to those in the room beyond the words you are trying to convey. Making sure you are professionally dressed using a confident tone and posture will ensure you keep the attention of your audience during your speaking.
- Think Strategically. When communicating with leadership you never want to present a problem without providing a solution. For C-Suite leadership, you want to have the big picture, future impact perspective. Analyze your solution

and be able to provide feedback on how it impacts the trajectory of the business. Ensure you have financials, people, and other relatable material.

References

- https://professional.dce.harvard.edu/blog/8-ways-you-can-improve-your-communication-skills/
- How Do You Communicate with C-Level Executives?